



**Lean machine:** This season, Ancy lost eight kilos from 63 to 55 and dropped to 13 per cent body fat. As the weight dropped, she started to soar. **Below:** Ancy with her father. RITU RAJ KONWAR & SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

jumped with her opening attempt in a competition. After a foul in her second attempt, she made clearances of 6.67m and then 6.72m. Each one of those jumps was significant — any of them would have won the competition — but Ancy wasn't satisfied.

She had been psyching herself up by replaying in her mind a scene from one of her favourite movies — *Bhaag Milkha Bhaag*.

"There's this scene where Milkha

Singh was wearing someone else's India jersey and was caught and got slapped by his coach. The coach tells him if you want to wear the Indian jersey you have to beat the man who wore it before you. That's when I started getting goosebumps and I started tearing up. That really inspired me. I told myself the same thing. I had to jump really big," she says.

That's when the jump happened. After a rapid sprint down the

track, Ancy found the board with her right cleat perfectly. She flew over the sand pit and landed further than any Indian woman ever had before.

### Looking beyond

At that moment, Ancy exulted. She thumped her chest in celebration and then fell to the track. But as the exhilaration of the moment subsided, she was already looking beyond the mark.

Her jump places her seventh on the world list this year but Ancy believes she doesn't have to be satisfied with that.

"This is a statement that India also has heavyweight jumpers. I wanted to prove that at the world level, India is also rising. I want to show and encourage youngsters to become good jumpers. But I'm not satisfied with this. I'm going to the Asian Games and I want to do something special there too. I also want to cross 7m," she says.

There is some concern that Ancy may have peaked too early in a domestic meet rather than at an international competition. But those who know her say that is unlikely to happen.

"I've seen Ancy for a long time. She's someone whose intensity never changes. She's the same everywhere. She could have jumped a National Record in a district meet or at the World Championships. If she's feeling good, she is going to jump big," says fellow Keralite and one of India's top men's long jumpers, Murali Sreeshankar.

Back home in Nattika, Sojan has no doubts that it will happen in Nagoya in a few months' time. He had hoped to be in Bhubaneswar but had to settle for watching Ancy jump on a *YouTube* stream while confined to bed rest following surgery.

He is happy with the record but knows Ancy can do more. He still drives his auto, but the taunts he received are vanishing specks in the rear-view mirror now.

"I always knew she would do something special, and she will do even more special things in the future," he says.

